

the country's mid-19th-century intelligentsia, that contested and shaped ideas of Russian national identity. He was born on March 18, 1844, in the provincial town of Tikhvin to a noble family. Music played an important part in his childhood, helped by his ability to repeat overheard melodies at the piano. The boy's older brother, however, encouraged him to join the Imperial Russian Navy, and in 1856 young Nika enrolled at the College of Naval Cadets in St. Petersburg. The move introduced him to the capital city's vibrant musical scene and, above all, to its captivating opera productions.

Private lessons in music theory and composition led to an introduction in 1861 to the composer Mily Balakirev, an ardent champion of nationalism in Russian music and leader of a select group of like-minded musicians. Balakirev became Rimsky-Korsakov's musical mentor and immediately instructed him to write a symphony. However, in 1862, midshipman Rimsky-Korsakov set sail on the clipper *Almaz* for a three-year term of service. On his return to St. Petersburg in the summer of 1865, he completed his *Symphony No. 1 in E minor, Op. 1*, ready for Balakirev to polish its contents and conduct its premiere at the city's Free Music School on December 31, 1865.